

Media as Political Currency*

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Abstract

This paper studies how executives deploy control over broadcast media to influence legislative coalitions. We develop a simple framework in which radio and television concessions operate as political currency: by raising a legislator's electoral valence, media ownership lowers the ideological cost of supporting the executive, making ideologically proximate legislators particularly attractive targets. We test these predictions using a newly assembled dataset that links all radio and TV licenses granted in Brazil during the 1987–1988 National Constituent Assembly to detailed electoral, biographical, and roll-call information for every candidate in the 1986 election. Exploiting narrow-margin victories within party–state coalitions in a regression discontinuity design, We show that winning a seat in the Assembly sharply increases the probability of receiving a concession, with effects concentrated among government-aligned legislators. Concession recipients subsequently vote more consistently with the executive on pivotal constitutional issues and later experience persistent electoral advantages, detectable more than a decade after democratization. Together, the results provide evidence that media concessions were strategically allocated to reshape legislative coalitions at a foundational moment of institutional redesign, with lasting implications for political competition in Brazil.

Keywords: Media Ownership, Political Influence, Legislative Behavior, Incumbency Advantage

JEL Classifications: P16, D72, L38

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1 Introduction

The strategic exchange of resources for legislative support is a central feature of democratic politics. Executives frequently rely on fiscal transfers and other forms of distributive spending to build and maintain congressional coalitions ([Golden and Min, 2013](#); [Stokes et al., 2013](#); [Cruz and Keefer, 2015](#); [Bonilla-Mejía and Morales, 2024](#)). Together, this literature shows that targeted benefits can shape legislative behavior, discipline coalition partners, and strengthen governing majorities. A parallel body of research highlights the political importance of the media, documenting how news exposure and media bias affect electoral behavior, political accountability, and even long-run institutional development ([Strömberg, 2015](#); [DellaVigna and Kaplan, 2007](#); [Enikolopov et al., 2011](#); [Grossman et al., 2022](#); [Cavgias et al., 2024](#); [Chong et al., 2017](#)). Yet despite extensive evidence that media shapes electoral and policy outcomes, we know almost nothing about how politicians come to control media in the first place and whether executives strategically allocate this control to influence the political process.¹

This paper examines the use of broadcast concessions as a form of political currency during Brazil’s transition to democracy. The mid-1980s in Brazil represented a period of profound institutional uncertainty, with an unpopular executive, a fragmented Congress, and the politically consequential task of drafting a new Constitution ([Mainwaring, 1999](#)). At that time, Brazilian regulation granted the president substantial discretion over the allocation and renewal of radio and television licenses ([Lopes, 2018](#); [Motter et al., 2019](#)). Moreover, in many regions radio stations were the dominant source of local political information, giving their owners considerable influence over voter perceptions. This combination of discretion and informational power created a setting in which broadcast concessions could plausibly function as targeted political transfers, allowing the Executive to strengthen legislative support during a foundational moment of constitutional redesign.

To study this executive–legislative exchange, we assemble new data linking all radio and television concessions granted between 1982 and the 2000s to individual politicians. We combine these administrative records with detailed electoral data from the 1986 Federal Deputy election, digitized roll-call votes from the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly (NCA), longitudinal election results from 1990 to 2010, and ex-

¹With the exception of [Boas and Hidalgo \(2011\)](#), who show in a non-experimental setting that owning a radio station increases a candidate’s electoral prospects, there is limited evidence on how politicians acquire media outlets or how executives may use media concessions to influence legislative coalitions.

tensive biographical information on candidates, their families, and their prior media involvement. This dataset allows us to follow every candidate for the NCA – winners and non-winners – and track whether, when, and what type of broadcast outlets they acquired.

To guide our empirical analysis, we develop a simple theoretical framework in which the Executive allocates media concessions to maximize legislative support. In the model, owning a media outlet increases a legislator’s electoral valence, reducing the electoral cost of siding with the government. In equilibrium, the Executive targets legislators who are ideologically proximate, as they require lower compensating transfers. Our framework clearly predicts which legislators should be targeted with concessions, how recipients should align in legislative votes, and the electoral advantage they should experience.

Guided by this framework, our empirical strategy exploits a narrow-margin Regression Discontinuity Design (RDD) within party–state coalitions in the 1986 election. Candidates who barely won became members of the NCA, while those who barely lost did not. If the Executive allocated concessions strategically, barely winning candidates aligned with the government should be more likely to receive licenses during the NCA. We complement the RDD with roll-call–voting analysis based on digitized historical records to test whether concession recipients were more likely to support the Executive in pivotal constitutional votes. Finally, we investigate medium and long-term effects of receiving media concessions using two complementary exercises. First, we estimate heterogeneous incumbency effects by comparing the subsequent electoral trajectories of concession recipients and non-recipients. We then complement this analysis with an instrumental-variables strategy that uses the narrow victory in 1986 as an instrument for concession receipt to investigate potential effects in subsequent elections.² In addition, consistent with the model’s prediction that the value of concessions should shape political behavior, we investigate whether licenses differ in their political relevance. In particular, we examine whether concessions granted in states with more concentrated pre-1986 media markets, as well as television stations, generate larger behavioral or electoral effects.

Our findings reveal a consistent pattern of politically motivated media allocation and its downstream consequences. Barely elected deputies became substantially more likely to receive radio concessions—between 9 and 15 percentage points relative to

²The exclusion restriction requires that the 1986 electoral result affects post-1990 outcomes only through its impact on receiving a media concession, which is unlikely to hold in the context of Brazil’s 1986 founding election. For this reason, we condition on deputies who were re-elected in 1990 and focus on outcomes from 1994 onward. We discuss this approach in more detail in Section 5.

a control mean of 0.4%, with effects nearing 20 percentage points among legislators aligned with the Executive, as predicted by the model. Concession recipients were also markedly more supportive of the Executive in pivotal constitutional roll-call votes, particularly those determining the adoption of the presidential system and the five-year presidential mandate.³ The magnitudes are sufficiently large to plausibly shift final vote margins on these institutional questions. Consistent with the mechanism, heterogeneity analyses show that legislators who received more valuable concessions were disproportionately responsive. Finally, we document suggestive evidence that recipients enjoyed higher reelection probabilities and larger vote-shares in subsequent elections, consistent with a persistent political advantage from media ownership.

This paper contributes to several strands of the literature. First, we build on the extensive research examining how changes in media market structure influence voting behavior (e.g., [Gentzkow et al., 2011](#); [Gavazza et al., 2018](#)) and policy choices (e.g., [Strömberg, 2004](#); [Snyder and Strömberg, 2010](#); [Drago et al., 2014](#)). A parallel literature shows that politically biased or targeted media can meaningfully shape electoral outcomes ([Adena et al., 2015](#); [Barone et al., 2015](#); [Martin and Yurukoglu, 2017](#); [Grossman et al., 2022](#); [Chong et al., 2017](#); [Cavglas et al., 2024](#)). Yet far less is known about how control of media outlets is allocated in the first place, especially when such outlets are granted directly by the Executive. With the exception of [Boas and Hidalgo \(2011\)](#), who use a regression-discontinuity design to show that incumbents are more likely to obtain community-radio licenses and then employ matching methods to show that ownership increases candidates' electoral prospects, evidence remains scarce – especially beyond the highly specific context of municipal community-radio concessions – on how politicians obtain media assets or whether executives strategically distribute concessions to shape legislative coalitions. We advance this literature by providing causal evidence that broadcast licenses granted during a legislative term substantially improve the electoral prospects of their political recipients, with potential implications for political competition and the long-term distribution of political power.

Second, the paper speaks to the literature on patronage, clientelism, and distributive politics, which studies how executives use targeted transfers, discretionary resources, and bureaucratic appointments to secure political support (e.g., [Golden and Min, 2013](#); [Stokes et al., 2013](#); [Cruz and Keefer, 2015](#)). Much of this work focuses on fiscal transfers, cash benefits, or public sector jobs as currency for political exchange.

³These votes were among the most consequential decisions of the National Constituent Assembly, determining Brazil's regime type and the political horizon of the incumbent President Sarney. In contrast, for issues where government preferences were less clearly defined—such as agrarian reform, property rights, work-hour regulation, job stability, and the right to strike—the pattern of support varied in line with the government's position documented in historical legislative records.

We show that broadcast concessions – an informational rather than fiscal resource – can function analogously as targeted political favors. By documenting a *quid pro quo* between the Executive and legislators during a constitutional moment, we extend classic theories of political exchange to a domain where the key transfer is informational capacity and control over local communication channels.

Third, we contribute to the literature on elite capture and the persistence of political power, which examines how incumbents manipulate institutional change or resource allocation to preserve political influence (Acemoglu and Robinson, 2008; Albertus and Menaldo, 2014). Related empirical work shows that elites make long-term investments during democratic transitions that shape the post-transition distribution of *de facto* political power (González et al., 2021; Martinez-Bravo et al., 2017). Our contribution is to uncover a previously undocumented mechanism of institutional capture, namely the acquisition of broadcast media licenses during the re-democratization process. We show that these concessions not only affected legislative behavior in the short run but also increased the long-term electoral success of their political recipients, thereby helping incumbent elites remain in power after the transition to democracy.

The remainder of this study is organized as follows. Section 2 explains why Brazil’s transition to democracy—and the 1986 Constituent Assembly in particular—created a rare opportunity to observe how executives deploy control over broadcasting licenses. Section 3 formalizes the mechanism motivating our analysis, presenting a simple framework in which media concessions raise legislators’ electoral valence and lower the ideological cost of supporting the Executive. Section 4 describes the data sources and variable construction, detailing how we link electoral records, media concession data, and legislative voting behavior. Section 5 tests the model’s predictions using a sequence of empirical exercises: we first establish that concession allocation responded to narrow victories in 1986; we then show that concession recipients systematically supported the government in pivotal constitutional votes; and finally we quantify the medium- and long-run electoral advantages conferred by media ownership. Finally, Section 6 concludes by discussing the broader implications of our findings for democratic accountability, institutional design, and the political economy of media control.

2 Background

Brazil’s system of media regulation historically granted the federal executive extensive discretion over the allocation and renewal of radio and television licenses. The

main legal framework from the 1960s⁴ allowed the president to designate the holder of AM radio and national TV concessions from among technically qualified applicants, while the Ministry of Communications exercised similar discretion over FM broadcasters (Motter et al., 2019). During the military regime, Decree-Law 236/1967 expanded these powers by allowing the state to fine, suspend, or revoke licenses without judicial oversight, a threat frequently used to discipline media outlets even though few revocations became formal actions (Lopes, 2018). These institutions created a regulatory environment in which broadcast concessions were highly valuable and heavily dependent on presidential favor.

By the early 1980s, Brazil was undergoing a process of redemocratization, with the military gradually transferring political authority back to civilian leaders after two decades in power. President José Sarney, who unexpectedly assumed office after Tancredo Neves's death, inherited a fragile economic environment marked by high inflation and the eventual failure of successive stabilization plans. Politically, Sarney lacked a cohesive partisan base and governed a Congress characterized by extreme fragmentation and weak party discipline. The largest governing party, the PMDB (Brazilian Democratic Movement Party), was a broad and internally heterogeneous centrist coalition that had served as the main legal opposition under the military regime. The PFL (Liberal Front Party), formally a center-right party and an important coalition partner, was composed largely of politicians who had supported the military regime and then repositioned themselves during the transition. Both parties exhibited substantial rates of legislative defection and weak internal cohesion (Mainwaring, 1999), complicating the Executive's efforts to build stable majorities.

The nationwide elections held in November 1986 selected the members of the National Constitutional Assembly (NCA), composed of 487 deputies and 72 senators, and were strongly influenced by the temporary popularity generated by the *Plano Cruzado*, an ambitious price-freeze stabilization program. Shortly after the election, however, inflation resurged and the plan quickly collapsed, leading to a sharp and well-documented decline in the government's popularity.⁵ Although the PMDB–PFL coalition secured a large number of seats, it remained internally divided (Motter et al., 2019). As a result, the executive needed to assemble majorities vote by vote on several ideologically divisive constitutional issues, including presidential term length, governmental system, property rights, and agrarian reform.

⁴Specifically the 1962 Código Brasileiro de Telecomunicações and the 1963 Regulamento dos Serviços de Radiodifusão. A contemporary example of political discretion in the allocation of radio concessions is reproduced in Figure B1.

⁵Appendix A, and particularly Figure B2, reproduces newspaper headlines from late 1986 to 1988 documenting the collapse of the *Cruzado* plan and the rapid decline in presidential approval.

In this environment, media concessions functioned as a particularly effective political currency. Broadcast outlets were economically attractive and electorally powerful given the central role of radio and television as sources of political information in Brazil, especially in areas with limited newspaper circulation (Boas, 2005; Porto, 2003; Lopes, 2018). Local radio stations, in particular, were often the primary venue for political news in smaller municipalities (Lopes, 2018). Historical accounts describe an uptick in the distribution of concessions during periods of intense political bargaining. For example, Motter et al. (2019) documents that during Sarney's presidency, approximately ninety legislators are reported to have received around radio and TV concessions over the course of the NCA. Although these accounts are descriptive and not intended to establish causal patterns, they underscore how valuable media outlets were perceived to be as bargaining instruments in the very period analyzed in this paper.

The structure of Brazil's media market further magnified the political returns to owning broadcast outlets. Television expanded rapidly during the military regime as part of a broader modernization strategy but evolved into a highly concentrated private market dominated by a small number of conglomerates (de Lima, 1988; Motter et al., 2019). A sizable literature documents how media owners have historically used their outlets to promote political allies and reduce the visibility of rivals (Costa and Brener, 1997; Santos and Capparelli, 2005; Stevanim and dos Santos, 2011). Complementing this qualitative evidence, recent quantitative work shows that owning a radio station increases a politician's vote share (Boas and Hidalgo, 2011; Lopes, 2018) and that voters respond to corruption audits only when local media are not controlled by political elites (Gehrke, 2019). Together, these institutional and informational features created a political landscape in which the executive had strong incentives to allocate media concessions strategically, legislators had strong incentives to obtain them, and media ownership plausibly shifted electoral prospects.

These characteristics make the Brazilian NCA a particularly compelling environment for studying how executives allocate media concessions, how these concessions shape legislative behavior, and how they translate into long-term political advantage.

3 Conceptual Framework

This section develops a simple theoretical framework in which the Executive uses media concessions as a political currency to influence legislative choices. The mechanism

follows [Bonilla-Mejía and Morales \(2024\)](#) but we allow for media concessions to raise incumbents' perceived valence, improving their reelection prospects and allowing the Executive to trade electoral benefits for ideological concessions. The Executive then allocates media benefits strategically to shift the implemented policy toward her preferred point.

Environment. There is an Executive who seeks to implement a policy $p \in [0, h]$ through the legislature. A continuum of legislators $\ell \in [0, 1]$ represent geographically distinct districts. Each district ℓ has a unique median voter with ideal point p_ℓ^* . Within district ℓ , individual voter ideal points are uniformly distributed around the median $\hat{v} \sim U[p_\ell^* - d, p_\ell^* + d]$.

Legislators are purely office-motivated, so their ideal point is simply the preferred policy of the median voter p_ℓ^* in their district. The median legislator in the aggregate assembly is located at $m = h/2$. The Executive has bliss point $e^* > m$, preferring a policy to the right of the legislative median.

District voters $j \in [0, 1]$ have single-peaked quadratic preferences: a voter with ideal point $\hat{v}$ obtains utility when the platform x is implemented in his district ℓ :

$$u_j(x) = -(x - \hat{v})^2 + \theta_j,$$

where θ_j is a candidate-specific valence term. The challenger positions at the district median $q = p_\ell^*$, while the incumbent legislator chooses a policy p_ℓ .

A media concession b_ℓ increases the incumbent's valence $\theta_I = \theta^0 + \gamma b_\ell$, yielding a valence advantage $\Delta\theta = \gamma b_\ell$.

Voter Choice and Vote Share. A voter compares the utility from the incumbent's position p_ℓ to that of the challenger's position $q = p_\ell^*$. The indifferent voter satisfies

$$-(p_\ell - \hat{v})^2 + \gamma b_\ell = -(p_\ell^* - \hat{v})^2.$$

Solving for the cutoff:

$$\hat{v}(p_\ell, b_\ell) = \frac{p_\ell + p_\ell^*}{2} - \frac{\gamma b_\ell}{2(p_\ell - p_\ell^*)}.$$

If $b_\ell = 0$, reduces to the standard Downsian indifferent voter, i.e., the voter whose ideal point is equidistant from the policies proposed by the challenger and the incum-

bent.

Assuming voter ideal points are uniformly distributed on $[p_\ell^* - d, p_\ell^* + d]$, the incumbent's vote share is:

$$s(p_\ell, b_\ell) = \frac{1}{2} - \frac{(p_\ell - p_\ell^*)}{4d} + \frac{\gamma b_\ell}{4d(p_\ell - p_\ell^*)}.$$

Legislator Incentives. Without concessions, the legislator maximizes reelection by choosing $p_\ell = p_\ell^*$. To induce support for the Executive's preferred policy $g > m$, the concession must satisfy:

$$s(g, b_\ell) \geq s(p_\ell^*, 0).$$

The minimum concession that induces this deviation is:

$$b^{\min}(p_\ell^*, g) = \frac{(g - p_\ell^*)^2}{\gamma}.$$

Districts whose medians are farther from g require larger concessions; sufficiently distant legislators cannot be bought at finite cost.

Executive Problem. Before legislators choose policy, the Executive announces a concession schedule $b(p_\ell^*, p_\ell)$, with allocations determined mechanically after choices.

To implement policy $g > m$, all legislators with $p_\ell^* < g$ must choose $p_\ell = g$. The least-cost incentive-compatible schedule is:

$$b_g(p_\ell^*, p_\ell) = \begin{cases} \frac{(g - p_\ell^*)^2}{\gamma}, & p_\ell^* < g, p_\ell = g, \\ 0, & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

The Executive faces a media-capacity constraint:

$$\int_0^h b(p_\ell^*, p_\ell) \frac{1}{h} dp_\ell^* \leq M.$$

Her utility from policy is quadratic loss:

$$U_E(g) = -(g - e^*)^2.$$

Thus, she chooses the most preferred feasible g that satisfies the media constraint and legislators' incentive constraints.

The model yields three testable implications:

1) Targeting of ideologically pivotal legislators. Only legislators whose district medians lie sufficiently close to g can be induced to support the Executive. Concessions concentrate on these pivotal districts.

2) Media compensates ideological deviation. Media benefits raise incumbents' valence and compensate for the electoral cost of deviating from district preferences. Therefore, targeted legislators should be more likely to support the Executive on ideologically salient roll-call votes.

3) Concessions enhance reelection prospects. Because valence directly increases vote share, legislators who receive concessions gain electoral advantages, generating incumbency effects aligned with the Executive's interest.

4 Data

To identify the ownership of radio and television concessions, we link firm-level corporate records from the *Cadastro Nacional de Empresas* (CNE)—Brazil's national registry of firms—with administrative data on all broadcasting licenses issued by the Ministry of Communications between 1979 and 2003. The CNE, which we obtained through a *Lei de Acesso à Informação* (LAI) request, is Brazil's equivalent of the U.S. Freedom of Information Act (FOIA). It compiles detailed registration information submitted to state-level *Juntas Comerciais* (Brazil's state corporate registry offices), including firms' federal tax identifiers (CNPJ, analogous to an EIN), partner names, individual tax IDs, and dates of incorporation. By matching these records to the Ministry's concession files through the CNPJ, we recover the ownership structure of media outlets at the time each license was granted or renewed.

We then connect media owners to political actors by linking individual-level records from the CNE to electoral data from the 1986 NCA elections. We begin with an exact full-name match within state, and then expand the search to surname-level matches (also within state boundaries), excluding overly common surnames (e.g., Silva, Santos, Oliveira, Souza) to avoid false positives. This two-step "blind" matching procedure produces a conservative but highly credible baseline: while it may miss some politically connected owners who registered concessions under proxies, it minimizes the risk of spurious links between politicians and firms.

To further validate and refine these matches, we use biographical information from two public archival sources: FGV-CPDOC (the Center for Research and Documenta-

tion of Contemporary History of Brazil, one of Brazil’s main political–historical archives) and the Chamber of Deputies’ official biographical database. These materials provide detailed information on family ties, career trajectories, and political affiliations. Cross-referencing these sources helps us identify some of the cases in which concessions were formally registered under spouses, children, business partners, or long-standing associates rather than the politician himself. This pattern is consistent with the widespread use of front men or straw owners (*laranjas*) documented in qualitative accounts of Brazilian media politics. Although these procedures significantly improve the accuracy of our ownership coding, it is still possible that some instances of indirect or concealed ownership remain undetected.

Finally, we complement our dataset with information assembled by [Motter et al. \(2019\)](#), who accessed original Ministry of Communications paper files and reconstructed concession histories for congressional investigations. His records, which rely on administrative documents unavailable in digital form, help identify additional cases of political ownership and validate the direction of our coding. Reassuringly, all empirical results remain robust when we restrict attention exclusively to the fully automated CNE–TSE matching procedure, though magnitudes become mechanically smaller – as expected from a stricter, fully blind linking strategy.⁶

Together, these steps yield a vetted dataset of political-media ownership links that is both comprehensive and conservative, and biases our estimates against finding effects.

Voting during the National Constituent Assembly. The 1988 National Constituent Assembly (NCA) was a landmark event in Brazil’s transition to democracy. As legislators debated the new Constitution, several contentious topics emerged, reflecting the competing interests of different political factions. The Assembly was not only a battleground for ideological disputes but also a crucial moment for President Sarney’s administration, which sought to maintain stability while navigating a rapidly chang-

⁶Excluding Motter’s archival records from the ownership measure reduces the estimated RDD effect of narrowly winning the 1986 election on concession receipt by roughly 40%. This is consistent with Motter’s dataset capturing additional cases of indirect or proxy ownership that our automated matching cannot detect. Crucially, the precision of the estimates remains nearly identical, and—more importantly—the downstream results on legislative behavior and long-term electoral advantage remain highly stable and statistically precise. This pattern strongly suggests that the discrepancy in magnitudes reflects classical measurement error in ownership coding rather than substantive bias. Moreover, we have no reason, *a priori*, to exclude Motter’s records: they result from extensive archival and journalistic documentation and likely capture numerous instances of indirect ownership (front men or *laranjas*) that fully automated linkages cannot identify. While we did not have access to the original documents underlying his compilation, the robustness of our results across specifications reinforces the validity of our media-ownership measure.

ing political landscape. Debates over agrarian reform, labor rights, property ownership, and the structure of the government itself revealed sharp divisions between progressive and conservative forces. Given the fragmented nature of the Assembly, the executive branch played an active role in influencing legislative outcomes, with media concessions serving as a potential tool for securing political support.

To examine legislative behavior during the NCA, we constructed a dataset of voting records from official documents published by the Brazilian Chamber of Deputies⁷. These documents, available in PDF format, provide detailed information on voting sessions, legislative debates, and voting outcomes.

The first step in our analysis involved extracting relevant data from these unstructured PDF documents using Optical Character Recognition (OCR). Since the PDFs contain both text and scanned pages, OCR was necessary to convert the material into a machine-readable format. After extraction, we performed manual validation and categorization, ensuring the accuracy of the dataset and classifying votes according to the topics debated in the Assembly.

Our dataset captures voting behavior on six of the most contentious issues debated during the NCA: Property Rights, Working Hours, Right to Strike, Presidential System of Government, Agrarian Reform and Employment Stability. Additionally, we included voting records on the five-year presidential mandate, an issue of particular importance to President Sarney, as he sought to extend his term beyond the originally anticipated four years. Since multiple votes were often cast on the same topic, we extracted the full set of voting records and classified them accordingly.

To identify the government's stance on each vote, we relied on official transcripts of Assembly speeches. During the constitutional debates, Mario Covas, the government's representative in the Assembly, publicly declared the executive's preferred positions on key issues. This allows us to determine whether deputies aligned with or opposed the government's agenda.

Using this information, we constructed a government loyalty score for each deputy, quantifying the extent to which their votes aligned with the government's preferred position. For each vote deputies received a score of 1 if they voted in favor of the government's position and a 0 score if they voted against it. For abstentions, a score of 1 if the government opposed the proposal, and 0 if the government supported it.

These individual scores were then aggregated and averaged across all votes for

⁷Available at: <https://www2.camara.leg.br/atividade-legislativa/plenario/discursos/escrevendohistoria/25-anos-da-constituicao-de-1988/momentos-marcantes-da-constituente>

each deputy and each topic, resulting in a continuous measure of government alignment, ranging from 0 (complete opposition) to 1 (full alignment). This score provides a quantitative assessment of how legislative support was distributed across different topics, allowing us to examine whether media concessions were associated with political alignment during the Assembly.⁸

Electoral Outcomes. To assess whether media concessions reinforced incumbency advantages after the 1988 National Constituent Assembly (NCA), we use electoral data from the Tribunal Superior Eleitoral (TSE), which provides detailed information on candidates, offices contested, and vote totals. Focusing on general elections from 1990 onward, we track whether NCA legislators who obtained media concessions were more likely to run for office again and to secure electoral success. This allows us to examine whether media ownership translated into a measurable and persistent political advantage.

5 Empirical Analysis

Descriptive Evidence. We begin by documenting broad descriptive patterns in the evolution of media concessions during the democratic transition. Figure 1 plots the cumulative number of radio and television licenses granted since 1979. Two features stand out. First, television concessions expanded rapidly in the early 1980s—particularly between 1979 and 1982—but their growth slowed substantially thereafter, including during the National Constituent Assembly (NCA). Second, and in sharp contrast, radio concessions exhibit a pronounced surge precisely in 1987–88, coinciding with the NCA period. This divergence is informative and suggests that radio stations were significantly cheaper to install and operate and had a more localized reach, making them a more flexible political resource than TV stations, whose expansion had largely stabilized before the NCA.

To connect these descriptive patterns with our empirical strategy, Figure 2 compares the evolution of media concessions for candidates who won or lost the 1986 election. While both groups experienced a gradual increase in concessions over the decade, a clear divergence emerges in 1987–88 with deputies elected in 1986 receiving substantially more concessions during the NCA. This sharp, election-linked shift is

⁸For additional details on how roll-call information was digitized, processed, validated, and aggregated – as well as a substantive description of each topic and its legislative relevance – refer to Appendix C.

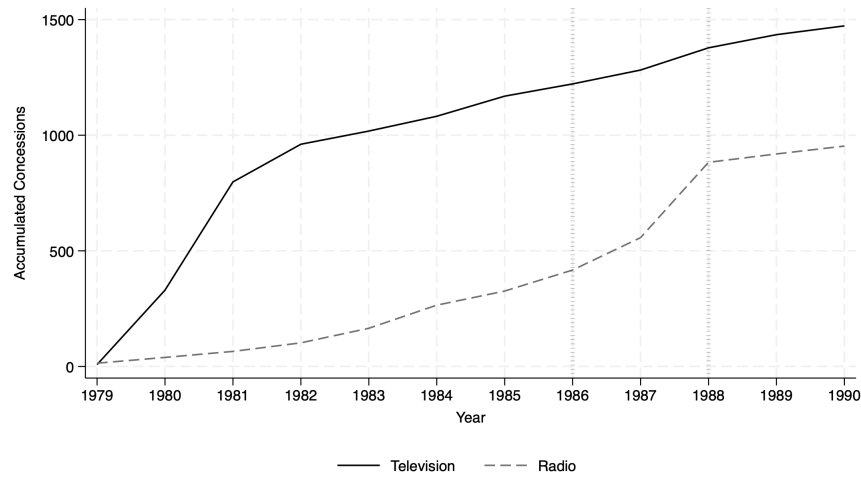


Figure 1: Accumulated TV and Radio Concessions Since 1979

Notes: Cumulative radio and television concessions granted between 1979 and 1990. Vertical dashed lines mark the 1987–88 Constituent Assembly. Data obtained via LAI request to the Ministry of Communications.

consistent with the key implication of our theoretical framework, in which the Executive allocates concessions strategically to legislators in exchange for political support.

These descriptive patterns motivate the causal analysis that follows, where we formally test whether narrow electoral victory in 1986 increased access to media stations and whether this politically valuable asset translated into legislative support and subsequent electoral advantage.

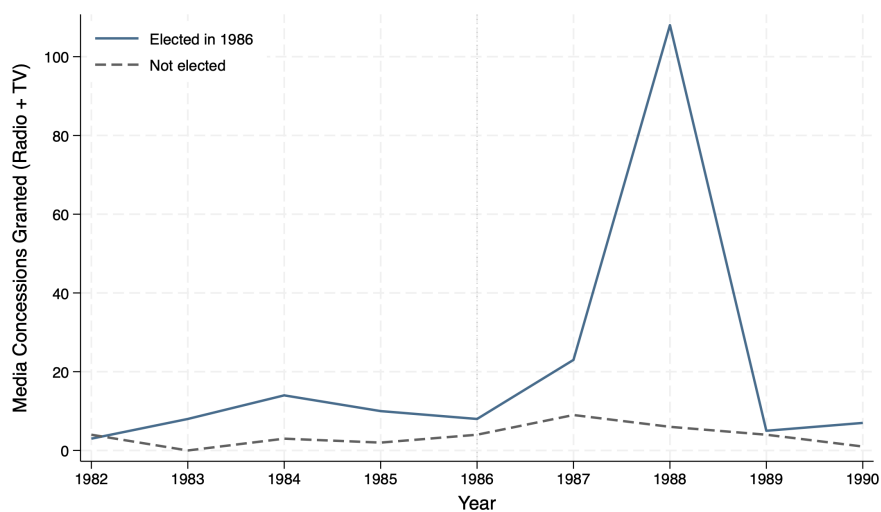


Figure 2: Media Concessions Granted Over Time, by 1986 Electoral Outcome

Effect of Electoral Victory on Media Concessions. To identify the effect of being elected as a National Constituent Assembly (NCA) deputy, we leverage quasi-random variation from close electoral races within Brazil’s open-list proportional representation system. Our running variable follows the approach used in the literature on proportional elections (Firpo et al., 2015; Novaes, 2024), comparing candidates within the same party-coalition and state according to their distance to the effective electoral threshold. This design allows us to compare candidates who narrowly secured a seat with those who narrowly missed, under the assumption that these individuals are otherwise similar with respect to relevant political and personal characteristics.

Figure 3 provides the first visual representation of our Regression Discontinuity (RD) design. The figure plots binned averages of the probability of receiving a media concession against the vote margin relative to the coalition threshold, together with local linear fits estimated separately on each side of the cutoff. A clear upward discontinuity appears indicating that candidates who barely won were substantially more likely to receive a concession than those who barely lost. This graphical evidence suggests that concession allocation was systematically related to electoral success rather than reflecting mechanical or random distribution.

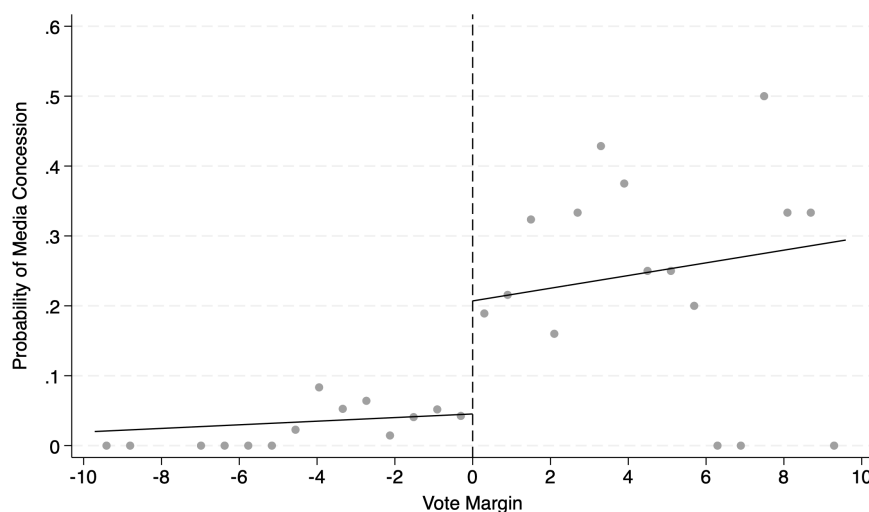


Figure 3: Media Concessions Granted Over Time, by 1986 Electoral Outcome

Table 1 formalizes this result by estimating local linear and quadratic RD specifications using optimal bandwidth selectors. Panel A reports the linear specification, while Panel B presents the corresponding quadratic model. Across both specifications, we uncover large and statistically precise effects: narrowly elected candidates were roughly 13–15 percentage points more likely to obtain a media concession than

narrowly defeated candidates. Given that the baseline concession rate among control candidates is only 0.4%, these estimates imply an increase of more than thirty times the control mean—an order-of-magnitude jump that indicates that electoral victory in 1986 dramatically expanded access to media ownership during the NCA.

Disaggregating the results by concession type reveals a pattern consistent with the institutional context described earlier. The RD effects are driven overwhelmingly by radio concessions, which expanded sharply during 1987–1988. Television concessions, which had mostly been allocated earlier in the decade, show smaller and less precise effects. This pattern is consistent with historical accounts [Motter et al. \(2019\)](#) documenting how radio licenses—being cheaper, more numerous, and more locally influential—became the primary instrument of political exchange during the constitution-writing period.

In Appendix [A](#), we present balance tests for predetermined covariates. Constructing these covariates required merging information from electoral records from subsequent years. To avoid having a large number of missing observations, we standardized the coding of variables drawn from electoral datasets—namely *Male*, *Non-white*, *Married*, *Age*, and *Bachelor degree*. Each indicator is coded as one whenever the corresponding characteristic can be observed either in the 1986 election dataset or in any subsequent electoral dataset. For example, *Bachelor degree* equals one only when the candidate reports a higher-education credential in at least one election; in all other cases we impute zero. Gender was identified using candidate registries complemented by name-based classification algorithms. Ideological positions were measured using the party-level scores from [Power and Zucco Jr \(2009\)](#), which we assign to candidates according to their party affiliation in 1986. For prior media ownership, we applied the same matching procedure used to identify media recipients in the main analysis.

Figure [A1](#) shows that, with the exception of the indicator for having been previously elected, observable characteristics evolve smoothly at the cutoff. Appendix Table [A1](#) shows that our main RD estimates remain virtually identical when restricting the sample to candidates who had not previously held elected office, reinforcing the validity of our identification strategy and supporting the interpretation of the discontinuity as causal.

In addition to these diagnostics, Appendix [A](#) examines the sensitivity of the RD estimates to alternative bandwidth choices and to placebo cutoffs. Figure [A2](#) shows the sequence of RD estimates obtained by scaling the bandwidth around the CCT-optimal choice. The point estimates stabilize quickly: while the smallest windows exhibit higher variance due to limited effective sample size, the estimates converge to

a tight and persistent range once the bandwidth reaches approximately the optimal window. Beyond this point, expanding the bandwidth has little effect on the estimates because almost all observations already lie sufficiently close to the cutoff; the marginal observations added at larger windows contribute minimal identifying variation. This pattern is exactly what would be expected if the treatment effect is local and the identifying variation comes from candidates narrowly above and below zero.

To further assess whether the observed discontinuity reflects genuine treatment assignment rather than broader non-linearities in the running variable, Figure A3 reports RD estimates computed at a series of placebo cutoffs away from zero. As shown in the figure, the estimates at alternative cutoffs fluctuate around zero with wide confidence intervals and display no systematic pattern, consistent with the absence of any meaningful discontinuity in media allocation at those thresholds. The only statistically precise and stable discontinuity occurs at the true electoral cutoff.

Table 1: RDD Estimates: Effect of Narrow Victories on Media Concessions

	TV or Radio	Radio	TV
Panel A: Linear specification			
RD Estimator	0.136** (0.036)	0.131** (0.035)	0.048* (0.023)
Eff. number obs.	1981	1884	2063
CCT-optimal BW	1.445	1.233	1.655
Panel B: Quadratic specification			
RD Estimator	0.154** (0.044)	0.141** (0.042)	0.070** (0.029)
Eff. number obs.	2121	2120	2144
CCT-optimal BW	1.868	1.856	2.026

Note: Panel A uses a linear RDD specification ($p = 1$); Panel B uses a quadratic specification ($p = 2$). Standard errors in parentheses. Asterisks denote significance at the *10%*, **5%*, and ***1%*** levels. CCT-optimal bandwidths and effective numbers of observations reported.

A central prediction of our theoretical model presented in Section 3 is that the Executive should strategically target legislators for whom support is “cheaper” in ideological terms. In other words, ideologically aligned deputies should be more responsive to media concessions, and thus more likely to receive them, whereas distant ideological opponents should require transfers so large that offering them concessions becomes suboptimal. To examine this theoretical prediction, we estimate heterogeneous RD effects by political alignment. Table 2 reports separate estimates for government supporters, the left opposition, and the right opposition. The results closely follow the model’s predictions. Government-aligned legislators exhibit large and precisely esti-

mated discontinuities, with narrowly elected supporters of the PMDB-led governing coalition being 18–20 percentage points more likely to receive a concession than narrowly defeated coalition candidates. In contrast, left-opposition candidates display no meaningful discontinuity, with point estimates close to zero across all concession types. This is exactly what the model predicts: when ideological distance is large, the compensating transfer required to secure support becomes prohibitively high, making these legislators unattractive targets.⁹

For the right opposition, ideologically closer to the Executive than the left but still outside the governing bloc, the estimated effects are positive but smaller and statistically weaker. This intermediate pattern is consistent with the model's comparative statics: as ideological distance increases, the optimal transfer declines smoothly and eventually becomes zero.

Taken together, our RD estimates paint a consistent empirical picture and indicate that media concessions responded systematically to electoral outcomes and ideological proximity, precisely as predicted by the model, with the Executive targeting pivotal legislators whose cooperation was both valuable and relatively less costly to obtain.

This logic naturally leads to our second empirical implication, that is, if concessions operate as targeted transfers, recipients should subsequently repay this political investment by supporting the Executive in legislative decision-making. In the next subsection, we examine whether deputies who received concessions during the NCA exhibited greater loyalty in roll-call votes on issues of particular importance to the Sarney administration.

Effect of Media Concessions on Voting Behavior. Having established that electoral victory in 1986 substantially increased the probability of receiving a media concession in 1987–88, we now examine whether these concessions were associated with legislative behavior during the National Constituent Assembly. The 1987–88 proceedings unfolded in a context of significant ideological conflict. Progressive groups within the PMDB and other center-left parties sought to advance redistributive and democratic reforms, whereas conservative factions, including former ARENA members and Sarney-aligned deputies, aimed to preserve existing privileges and limit institutional change. Although the PMDB held a formal majority, internal divisions meant that control over the drafting process shifted over time, most notably after a procedural reform

⁹Appendix Table A2 shows that these heterogeneous effects do not change significantly when restricting the sample to candidates without prior electoral experience, reinforcing that the alignment patterns are not driven by previous incumbency.

Table 2: RDD Estimates by Political Alignment (Linear Specification)

	TV or Radio	Radio	TV
Panel A: Government-Aligned Legislators			
RD Estimator	0.206** (0.051)	0.182** (0.047)	0.090* (0.034)
Eff. number obs.	1015	1033	1045
CCT-optimal BW	0.979	1.010	1.038
Panel B: Left Opposition			
RD Estimator	-0.040 (0.033)	-0.036 (0.028)	-0.007 (0.015)
Eff. number obs.	334	251	331
CCT-optimal BW	0.564	0.481	0.543
Panel C: Right Opposition			
RD Estimator	0.098 (0.062)	0.099 (0.065)	0.038 (0.049)
Eff. number obs.	483	553	599
CCT-optimal BW	0.870	1.094	1.124

Notes: All estimates from `rdrobust` using a linear specification ($p = 1$). Standard errors in parentheses. Asterisks denote significance at the *10%, **5%, and ***1% levels. Effective number of observations and CCT-optimal bandwidths reported.

in early 1988 that strengthened conservative influence (Weller and Limongi, 2024).

Against this background, several issues became central to the government’s legislative strategy: agrarian reform, labor rights (work hours, right to strike, and job stability), property rights, the presidential system of government, and, in particular, the length of the presidential term. Progressive deputies generally supported stronger worker protections and a four-year presidential term, while government and conservative allies prioritized maintaining the presidential system and securing a five-year mandate for President Sarney. These issues thus provide a natural setting for examining whether access to media concessions shaped legislative loyalty.

To study this question, we rely on the roll-call dataset described in Section 4 and Appendix C. For each deputy and each topic, we measure the proportion of votes aligned with the government’s publicly stated preferences. Our empirical strategy compares deputies who received a concession with deputies who did not, conditioning on party-by-state fixed effects to absorb persistent ideological and regional differences. We also control for candidates’ 1986 vote margin and for any media concessions obtained prior to 1987, ensuring that comparisons are made among deputies with sim-

ilar underlying political viability and pre-existing media connections.

Table 3 summarizes the results. For most redistributive issues, such as agrarian reform, right to strike, work hours, and property rights, the estimated effects are small in magnitude and either statistically insignificant or only slightly negative. These modest coefficients are consistent with the view that voting on broad distributive topics was driven primarily by ideological alignment and party factionalism rather than by targeted transfers.

In contrast, large and precisely estimated associations emerge for presidentialism and for the five-year presidential term. Deputies who received concessions were about 24 percentage points more likely to support the presidential system and 36 percentage points more likely to back the five-year term, relative to deputies who did not receive concessions and compared within the same state-party cell. Given the respective control-group means (0.54 and 0.48), these effects represent increases of roughly 45 percent and 75 percent. These substantial relative increases suggest that concession recipients were considerably more supportive of the institutional arrangements most directly tied to the Executive's preferences and political survival.

Table 3: Effect of Media Concessions (1987–88) on Government Loyalty in Roll-Call Votes

	(1) Agrarian Reform	(2) Right to Strike	(3) Job Stability	(4) Work Hours	(5) Property Rights	(6) Presidential System	(7) Five-Year Term
Media Concession, 1987-88	-0.067** (0.026)	-0.110*** (0.028)	0.110*** (0.034)	-0.029 (0.019)	-0.008 (0.026)	0.243*** (0.047)	0.362*** (0.067)
State × Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean of Control Group	0.60	0.81	0.68	0.74	0.70	0.54	0.48
Observations	451	451	451	451	451	451	451
R ²	0.34	0.35	0.36	0.20	0.22	0.36	0.43

Notes: Each column reports coefficients from separate regressions of a deputy's pro-government vote on an indicator for receiving a media concession (radio or TV) in 1987–88. All specifications control for (i) the candidate's vote margin in the 1986 election (to account for popularity, candidate quality, and electoral competitiveness), and (ii) pre-1987 media ownership (radio or TV, self or relatives). Standard errors (in parentheses) are clustered at the state level. State-by-year fixed effects included in all models. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

The results are broadly consistent with the model's prediction that media concessions strengthened pro-government legislative support. Radio concessions produce uniformly positive effects across all major topics, and TV concessions show similarly pro-government patterns for six of the seven issues. The only exception is the *Property Rights* vote, where the point estimate for TV recipients is negative. This divergence is not surprising given the political dynamics surrounding this specific topic.

First, TV concessions were disproportionately granted in larger and more urban states, where conservative factions were internally divided on land- and property-related provisions. Historical accounts show that VHF television licenses—far scarcer and more politically valuable than local radio stations—were allocated to factions within PMDB and PFL that were themselves split on elements of the government’s preferred language on property rights, generating a more heterogeneous treated group precisely on this dimension. Second, unlike issues such as presidentialism or the five-year term—where the Executive articulated clear and unified positions—the property-rights agenda involved multiple amendments with cross-cutting ideological alignments, making the interpretation of a single “pro-government” coding inherently less straightforward.

Table 4: Effect of Media Concessions (1987–88) on Government Loyalty in Roll-Call Votes, by Type of Media

	(1) Agrarian Reform	(2) Right to Strike	(3) Job Stability	(4) Work Hours	(5) Property Rights	(6) Presidential System	(7) Five-Year Term
Panel A							
TV Concession (1987–88)	-0.133 (0.084)	-0.057 (0.079)	0.062 (0.111)	-0.085*** (0.028)	-0.032 (0.056)	0.185 (0.134)	0.539*** (0.085)
Mean Control	0.61	0.81	0.67	0.74	0.70	0.54	0.47
Observations	349	349	349	349	349	349	349
R-squared	0.33	0.32	0.35	0.22	0.24	0.35	0.41
Panel B							
Radio Concession (1987–88)	-0.069*** (0.025)	-0.058* (0.030)	0.076** (0.037)	-0.033 (0.021)	0.005 (0.023)	0.155** (0.059)	0.221*** (0.072)
Mean Control	0.61	0.81	0.67	0.74	0.70	0.54	0.47
Observations	419	419	419	419	419	419	419
R-squared	0.34	0.30	0.36	0.21	0.22	0.34	0.40

Notes: Each column reports coefficients from regressions of government-aligned voting on an indicator for receiving a media concession in 1987–88. All specifications include state $\times$ year fixed effects. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the state level. Mean Control reports the average pro-government voting rate among legislators without media concessions. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Next, we examine whether the political value of media concessions varied across contexts. The idea is that the effectiveness of a concession should depend on how valuable media ownership is in a deputy’s home state. To proxy for this, we use pre-1986 media-market competitiveness, measured by the number of *Fistel* registrations per municipality in 1985. The *Fistel* (Fundo de Fiscalização das Telecomunicações) is Brazil’s national telecommunications registry: every radio or television broadcaster must hold a valid *Fistel* registration to operate, making the number of registrations a reliable proxy for the density and competitiveness of local media markets. In states

where the media market was highly concentrated, with only a few registered broadcasters, obtaining a concession likely granted the recipient a disproportionate share of local visibility and influence. By contrast, in more competitive markets, the marginal political value of an additional outlet was presumably smaller.

Table 5 reports the estimates separately for states with non-competitive media markets (Panel A) and competitive ones (Panel B). The pattern is highly consistent with the notion that concessions were politically more valuable where media markets were more concentrated. In non-competitive states media concessions generate uniformly positive and precisely estimated effects on government loyalty across most topics. Deputies who received concessions were substantially more supportive of the Executive on job stability, presidentialism, and especially the five-year presidential term, with effect sizes nearly twice as large as in the pooled specification.

By contrast, in competitive states (Panel B), where the marginal informational reach of a single broadcaster was lower, the effects are noticeably weaker and more heterogeneous. Some coefficients become small or even negative, particularly for right to strike and property rights, suggesting that in saturated media markets concession recipients behaved more in line with their pre-existing ideological commitments. Nevertheless, for the issues most central to the administration's institutional agenda, such as presidentialism and the five-year term, the estimated effects remain positive and sizeable even in competitive markets.

Taken together, the results are consistent with the prediction developed in Section 3 that media concessions functioned as targeted transfers designed to secure support from pivotal legislators. We find no systematic relationship between concessions and votes on issues where ideological positions were steep and costly to shift. Instead, the associations concentrate on decisions that were especially valuable to the Executive and for which deputies closer to the government could be persuaded at lower ideological cost. This logic motivates the next step of the analysis, where we investigate whether media concessions also translated into persistent electoral advantages.

Electoral Advantage. We now examine the third empirical implication of our framework: deputies who received media concessions should experience subsequent political gains. Table 6 shows that concession recipients were about 20 percentage points more likely to run again in 1990, relative to a mean of 33 percent among non-recipients. From 1994 onward, the coefficients become small and statistically indistinguishable from zero, suggesting that the effect on political participation is concentrated in the first electoral cycle.

Table 5: Effect of Media Concessions (1987–88) on Government Loyalty in Roll-Call Votes, by Media Market Competitiveness

	(1) Agrarian Reform	(2) Right to Strike	(3) Job Stability	(4) Work Hours	(5) Property Rights	(6) Presidential System	(7) Five-Year Term
Panel A: Non-Competitive Media Markets							
Media Concession, 1987-88	-0.019 (0.020)	-0.075 (0.047)	0.169*** (0.044)	0.011 (0.025)	-0.007 (0.039)	0.169** (0.072)	0.339*** (0.076)
Mean Control	0.58	0.76	0.70	0.74	0.71	0.52	0.54
Observations	172	172	172	172	172	172	172
R-squared	0.46	0.32	0.28	0.21	0.29	0.49	0.55
Panel B: Competitive Media Markets							
Media Concession, 1987-88	-0.113*** (0.038)	-0.142*** (0.032)	0.052 (0.051)	-0.071*** (0.025)	-0.011 (0.036)	0.307*** (0.055)	0.391*** (0.111)
Mean Control	0.61	0.83	0.66	0.75	0.70	0.55	0.44
Observations	279	279	279	279	279	279	279
R-squared	0.29	0.34	0.40	0.22	0.19	0.28	0.35

Notes: Each column reports coefficients from regressions of government-aligned voting on an indicator for receiving a media concession in 1987–88. All specifications include state $\times$ party fixed effects, control for the candidate’s vote margin in 1986, and for all media concessions received prior to 1987. Standard errors in parentheses are clustered at the state level. “Competitive” media markets are states with an above-median number of *Fistel* registrations per municipality in 1985; “non-competitive” states fall below this threshold. *Fistel* records capture the number of licensed broadcasting outlets, serving as a proxy for media-market density. Mean Control reports the average government-support rate for deputies without a concession. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table 6: Effect of Winning Media Concessions in 1987–1988 on Future Electoral Participation

	Dependent variable: Ran for federal deputy in year t					
	1990	1994	1998	2002	2006	2010
Won Media Concessions, 1987–88	0.203*** (0.026)	-0.014 (0.033)	0.083** (0.035)	0.067 (0.043)	0.039 (0.039)	0.025 (0.026)
Mean of dependent var.	0.33	0.14	0.13	0.10	0.08	0.05
Observations	2,509	2,509	2,509	2,509	2,509	2,509
R^2	0.14	0.18	0.18	0.16	0.11	0.10
State $\times$ Party FE	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Post-Media Controls	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the party–state level in parentheses. All specifications include state–party fixed effects and control for radio and TV concessions (self and relatives) in all years prior to t . * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

More importantly, we next ask whether media concessions translated into electoral advantages conditional on running. This exercise is inherently challenging because media access is endogenous and a naive IV strategy using the 1986 victory as an instrument would likely violate the exclusion restriction since the 1986 shock plausibly affects later electoral performance through multiple channels, including name recognition, political capital, and incumbency effects. We therefore rely on a set of complementary analyses to investigate this important question.

First, Table 7 reports OLS estimates of the effect of receiving a concession on subsequent vote shares, controlling for state-party fixed effects and all prior media ownership. Across all post-1990 elections, the OLS estimates reveal no systematic differences in vote shares between concession recipients and non-recipients. This is unsurprising since OLS estimates likely conflate media effects with unobserved determinants of electoral strength, and incumbency in 1986 may have shaped later outcomes through several non-media channels.

In Panel B of Table 7, we exploit the close-election assignment of 1986 as an instrument for receiving a concession. A standard exclusion restriction would require that the 1986 electoral shock affects later vote shares *only* through media ownership, a strong assumption given that winning in 1986 also increased political visibility, party leverage, and, crucially, the probability of being re-elected in 1990. To address this concern, we adopt a weaker and more credible restricted exclusion restriction. For elections from 1994 onward, we condition explicitly on incumbency in 1990 by restricting the sample to candidates who held office in that term. Under this assumption, the 1986 shock can affect post-1994 outcomes only through two channels: holding a media concession or gaining incumbency in 1990. This restriction rules out any direct effect of the 1986 victory on future electoral performance other than through these two mechanisms.

Within this framework, the IV estimates are positive, sizable, and statistically significant in several election years. The effects are strongest in 1994 and 1998 – roughly one and two electoral cycles after the concessions were granted – suggesting that media ownership generated meaningful and persistent electoral advantages. As time passes, however, two patterns naturally emerge. First, the magnitude of the coefficients declines, consistent with the idea that the electoral value of media concessions decays as political conditions evolve. Second, standard errors widen substantially in the 2002, 2006, and especially 2010 elections. This reflects the sharp reduction in sample size over time, as many candidates exit the political arena, which increases sampling variance and limits statistical precision. Taken together, the IV results indicate

that media concessions conferred durable but not permanent electoral benefits, with detectable effects lasting for more than a decade after the initial allocation.

Table 7: Effect of Winning Media Concessions in 1987–1988 on Future Electoral Performance

	Dependent variable: Vote Share in Federal Deputy Elections					
	1990	1994	1998	2002	2006	2010
Panel A: OLS Estimates						
Won Media Concessions, 1987–88	0.073 (0.101)	0.661 (0.508)	0.252 (0.367)	0.050 (0.319)	0.575 (0.390)	1.816*** (0.408)
Mean of dependent var.	1.06	1.29	1.10	1.04	0.93	0.96
Observations	545	158	203	131	109	54
R ²	0.71	0.74	0.75	0.76	0.77	0.93
Panel B: IV Estimates (2SLS)						
Won Media Concessions, 1987–88	–	4.126*** (1.213)	4.752*** (1.410)	2.021 (1.453)	3.881*** (1.324)	9.624 (15.661)
Mean of dependent var.	–	1.16	1.16	1.16	1.16	1.16
Observations	–	128	171	112	88	54
R ²	–	0.38	0.17	0.72	0.53	–

Notes: Standard errors clustered at the party–state level in parentheses. OLS specifications include state–party fixed effects and control for all radio and TV concessions (self and relatives) received prior to 1987. IV estimates use the close-election assignment from 1986 as an instrument for receiving a concession in 1987–88 and include the same controls. Mean of dependent variable refers to the election-year-specific average vote share. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

To complement our analysis of long-term electoral persistence, Figure 4 plots the estimated 1986 incumbency effect separately for deputies who did and did not receive media concessions. Among non-recipients, the incumbency advantage fades rapidly already by the mid-1990s and remains close to zero thereafter. Among concession recipients, by contrast, the effect is consistently larger and more persistent, remaining positive across multiple electoral cycles. While these estimates are descriptive—since media ownership is not randomly assigned, they corroborate the IV results by showing that the discontinuity at the 1986 threshold translates into a more durable incumbency premium specifically for concession recipients, consistent with the interpretation that media access helped sustain political advantage over time.

Figure 5 introduces a second source of heterogeneity by comparing the incumbency effect across states with high and low pre-1986 media-market competitiveness. The pattern aligns closely with the earlier legislative results. In non-competitive markets, where a new broadcasting outlet delivered substantial marginal visibility, the incumbency effect remains positive and persistent across several elections. In more competitive markets, where concessions likely carried lower political returns, incumbency effects are smaller and fade more quickly. The negative point estimates observed in

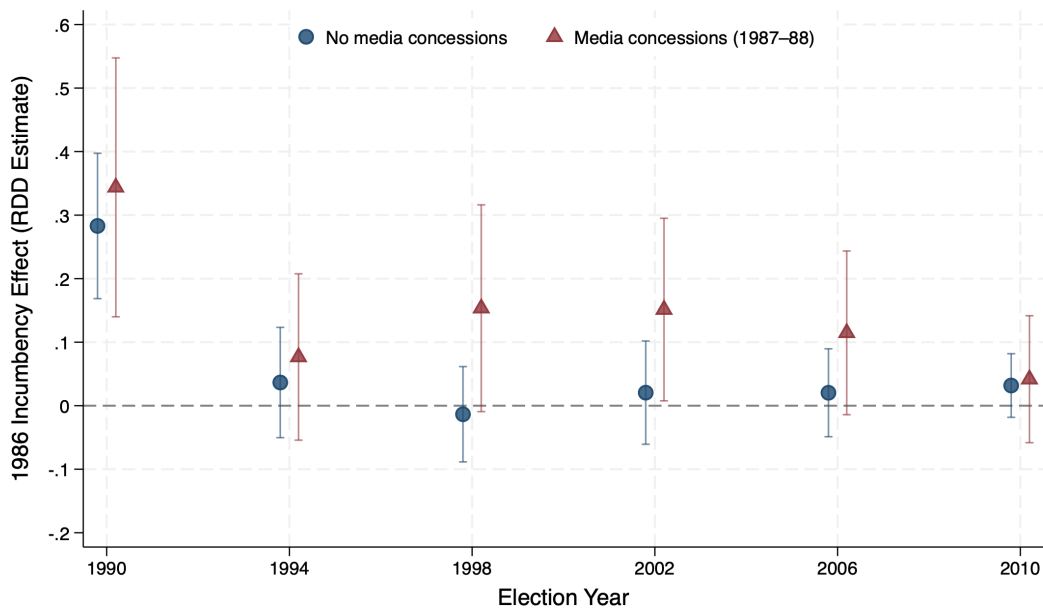


Figure 4: RDD Estimates of the 1986 Incumbency Effect by Media-Concession Status

Notes: Each point plots the estimated incumbency effect from a local linear regression discontinuity design centered at the 1986 electoral threshold, separately for deputies who received media concessions in 1987–88 and for those who did not. Vertical bars represent 95% confidence intervals. Estimates shown for federal deputy elections from 1990 to 2010.

the late 2000s for competitive states should not be over-interpreted, as they appear imprecise, stem from small sample sizes in later electoral cycles, and are consistent with regression-to-zero once the original treatment shock loses relevance. Overall, this exploratory evidence reinforces the interpretation that the political value of media concessions was strongest in concentrated media environments.

6 Conclusion

This paper studies how control over broadcast media can be strategically deployed to reshape legislative coalitions and generate long-term political advantage. Using a new dataset linking a neraly universal information on radio and television concessions to individual politicians, combined with close-election RDD designs and a simple conceptual framework, we show that Brazil’s Executive used media concessions as a form of political currency during the country’s transition to democracy. Narrowly elected members of the 1986 Constituent Assembly were substantially more likely to

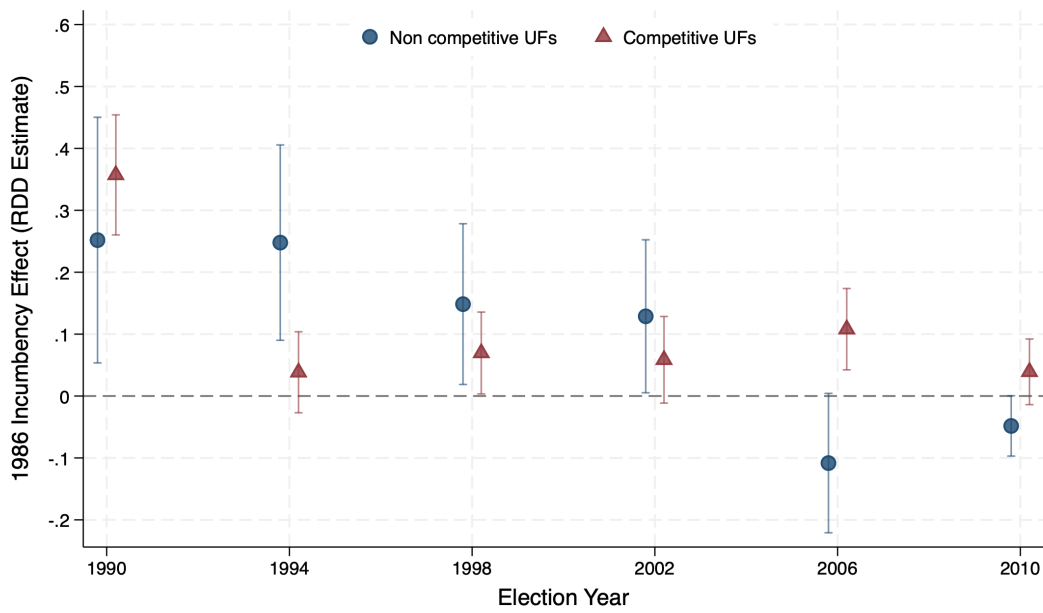


Figure 5: RDD Estimates of the 1986 Incumbency Effect by Pre-1986 Media-Market Competitiveness

Notes: States are classified as “competitive” or “non-competitive” based on whether their 1985 number of *Fistel* broadcasting registrations per municipality lies above or below the national median. Each point shows the estimated incumbency effect from a local linear regression discontinuity design for each subgroup. Confidence intervals at the 95% level.

receive radio and TV licenses in 1987–88, with the effects concentrated among ideologically aligned legislators—precisely as the model predicts. These concessions, in turn, meaningfully increased legislative support for the Executive on the most consequential votes of the constitutional process, including presidentialism and the five-year presidential mandate.

Beyond their immediate legislative impact, media concessions generated persistent electoral advantages. Deputies who acquired concessions exhibited higher reelection rates and substantially larger vote shares in subsequent federal elections. These advantages were strongest in states with highly concentrated media markets and attenuated in more competitive environments, consistent with the idea that the political value of a concession depends on its local informational reach. RDD estimates across multiple elections and IV estimates using the close-election shock as an instrument both point to medium-run persistence, though the effects naturally become noisier as the sample shrinks in later cycles. Taken together, the evidence indicates that politically allocated media access—rather than mere incumbency alone—played a mean-

ingful role in the consolidation of political power after democratization.

These findings contribute to several strands of research. First, they expand the media–politics literature by documenting not only how media influences voters, but how control over media is allocated in the first place, and how this allocation shapes both legislative behavior and long-term political competition. Existing work emphasizes biased coverage or media entry, we show that media ownership itself, when politically granted, operates as a durable electoral asset. Second, the results speak to the literature on elite persistence and institutional capture. Prior research highlights economic power, coercion, or informal institutions as mechanisms of elite entrenchment. This paper documents a distinct pathway: elites consolidate political influence by acquiring strategic informational assets during moments of institutional flux. In transitional settings where formal constraints are weak, broadcast concessions function as a powerful instrument of *de facto* political power.

Our findings raise important questions for future research. While we document a strong link between media ownership and political advantage, further investigation is needed to understand the long-term consequences of these concessions on political competition, policymaking, and economic development. For instance, does media control by politicians lead to more clientelistic policies or lower government accountability? Does the legislative behavior of media-owning deputies remain different in subsequent periods? Moreover, does receiving media concessions impact the political participation of politicians’ relatives, facilitating the emergence of dynasties? Additionally, exploring similar mechanisms in other democratizing contexts could shed light on whether media concessions are a broader tool of elite entrenchment in institutional transitions. By advancing our understanding of how media influences political power, this study contributes to the broader discussion on the role of information in democratic governance.

These results open several avenues for further research. A first natural step is to investigate the mechanisms through which concession recipients convert media ownership into political advantage. Do media-owning legislators face weaker electoral accountability, engage differently in distributive politics, or shape local information environments in ways that reinforce their political position? A second question concerns intergenerational transmission: given the persistence of media assets within families, concession recipients may have facilitated the emergence or strengthening of political dynasties. A third direction is comparative. The Brazilian NCA offers an unusually transparent setting for studying the political allocation of broadcasting rights, but discretionary media control has played an important role in other democratizing con-

texts as well. Understanding whether similar mechanisms operated in Latin America, Southern Europe, or Eastern Europe would shed light on the broader role of media assets in episodes of institutional transition and democratic consolidation. Together, these questions point to a broader research agenda on how informational resources shape political power over time and across settings.

Finally, our results underscore the importance of regulatory frameworks that prevent the use of media concessions for political bargaining. Policy measures such as increasing transparency in the allocation of broadcasting licenses, implementing competitive bidding processes, and enforcing stricter conflict-of-interest laws for politicians who own media outlets could help mitigate the entrenchment of political elites through media control. More broadly, our study suggests that media ownership laws should be designed to prevent undue political influence while ensuring pluralism in media markets, particularly in emerging democracies where institutional safeguards are still developing. The implications of our findings extend beyond historical media concessions and remain highly relevant in today's media landscape, where ownership concentration among a small number of influential individuals raises concerns about political influence and democratic accountability.

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A Additional Tables and Graphs

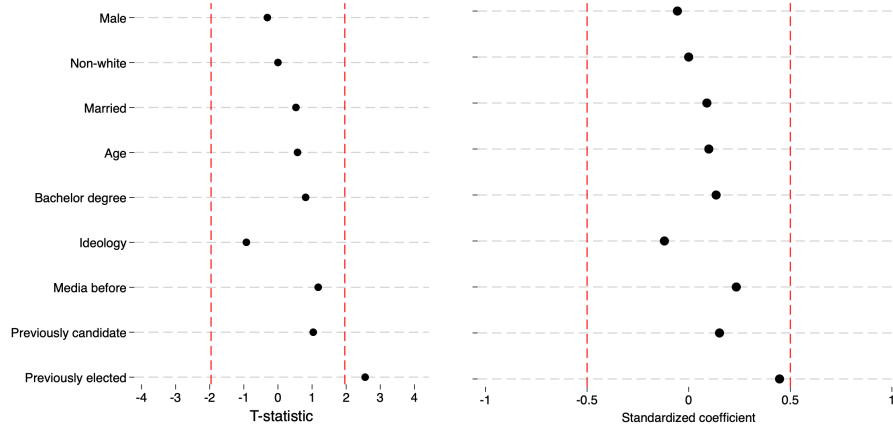


Figure A1: Baseline Covariate Balance Around the 1986 Electoral Threshold

Notes: This figure displays bias-corrected robust t-statistics (left panel) and standardized coefficients (right panel) from our baseline covariate balance tests around the 1986 coalition threshold. For each covariate, we estimate a regression discontinuity design using a local linear specification with a uniform kernel. Bandwidths correspond to the CCT-optimal bandwidth. In the t-statistic panel, red dashed lines mark the 5% significance thresholds (± 1.96).

Table A1: RDD Estimates: Robustness Excluding Previously Elected Candidates

	TV or Radio	Radio	TV
Panel A: Linear specification			
RD Estimator	0.0897*	0.0889*	0.0345*
	(0.0498)	(0.0489)	(0.0272)
Eff. number obs.	1484	1445	1314
CCT-optimal BW	1.3802	1.2951	1.0169
Panel B: Quadratic specification			
RD Estimator	0.1103*	0.0984*	0.0452*
	(0.0630)	(0.0590)	(0.0295)
Eff. number obs.	1615	1643	1565
CCT-optimal BW	1.9039	2.0752	1.6429

Note: This table reports RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning the 1986 election on receiving media concessions in 1987–88. To address the imbalance in the indicator for previously elected politicians documented in Appendix A, we restrict the sample to candidates who had not previously held elected office. Panel A presents estimates from a linear RDD specification ($p = 1$), and Panel B reports results from a quadratic specification ($p = 2$). Standard errors are shown in parentheses. Asterisks denote significance at the *10%, **5%, and ***1% levels. CCT-optimal bandwidths and effective numbers of observations are reported. Results closely mirror the baseline estimates, indicating that our conclusions are not driven by prior incumbency.

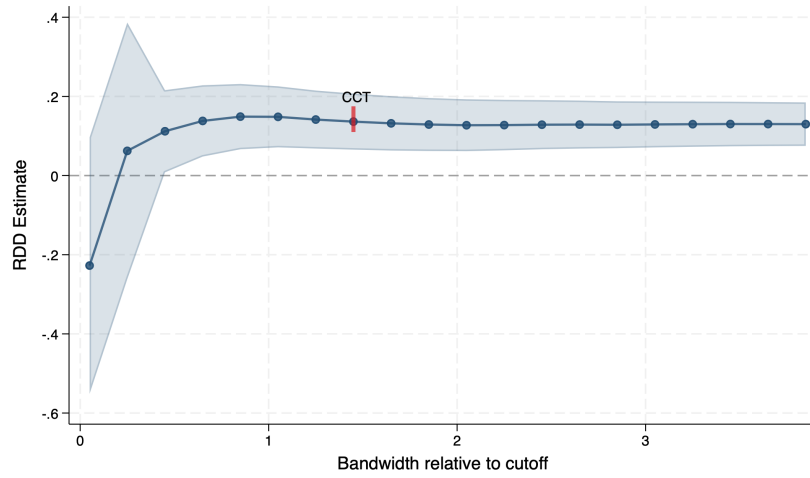


Figure A2: Bandwidth Sensitivity of the 1986 RDD Estimate

Notes: Each point reports the estimated RDD effect of narrowly winning the 1986 election on the probability of receiving a media concession, using a local linear specification and bandwidths scaled relative to the CCT-optimal bandwidth. Shaded regions show 95% confidence intervals. The vertical mark indicates the CCT-optimal bandwidth.

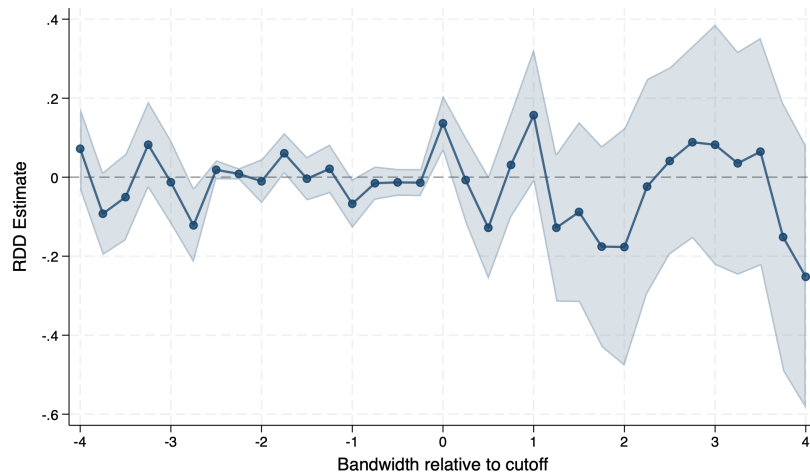


Figure A3: Sensitivity of the RDD Estimate to Alternative Vote-Margin Cutoffs

Notes: Each point shows the estimated incumbency effect from a local linear RDD using alternative symmetric bandwidths around the vote-margin cutoff, ranging from -4 to $+4$. Shaded regions depict 95% confidence intervals. This exercise examines the stability of the RDD estimate under broader or narrower windows around the cutoff.

Table A2: RDD Estimates by Political Alignment (Robustness to Excluding Previously Elected Candidates)

	TV or Radio	Radio	TV
Panel A: Government-Aligned Legislators (PMDB–PFL)			
RD Estimator	0.148** (0.074)	0.136** (0.069)	0.059 (0.039)
Eff. number obs.	726	765	655
CCT-optimal BW	1.247	1.382	0.949
Panel B: Left Opposition			
RD Estimator	-0.022 (0.026)	0.002 (0.002)	-0.014 (0.020)
Eff. number obs.	277	141	290
CCT-optimal BW	0.576	0.381	0.602
Panel C: Right Opposition			
RD Estimator	0.123 (0.149)	0.124 (0.149)	0.010 (0.006)
Eff. number obs.	438	438	312
CCT-optimal BW	0.982	0.974	0.486

Note: This table reports RDD estimates of the effect of narrowly winning the 1986 election on receiving media concessions, separately by political alignment. To address the imbalance in the indicator for previous electoral experience documented, the sample is restricted to candidates who had not previously held elected office. All estimates rely on a linear RDD specification ($p = 1$). Standard errors are reported in parentheses. Asterisks denote significance at the *10%, **5%, and ***1% levels. CCT-optimal bandwidths and effective numbers of observations are shown. The results closely parallel our baseline findings, indicating that political alignment patterns are not driven by prior incumbency.

B Contemporary Newspaper Evidence

This appendix presents contemporary newspaper material illustrating two central features of the institutional environment surrounding the National Constitutional Assembly (NCA): (i) the political salience and discretionary nature of broadcast concessions, and (ii) the sharp decline in President José Sarney's popularity following the post-election collapse of the *Plano Cruzado*.

Figure B1 reproduces a front-page story from *Folha de S. Paulo*, published on November 15, 1988, describing the political allocation of radio concessions in the state of Bahia. The report describes how the Minister of Communications, Antonio Carlos Magalhães, distributed radio broadcasting licenses to political allies.



Figure B1: Contemporary newspaper story documenting the distribution of radio concessions to political allies in Bahia.

Figure B2 presents a compilation of newspaper headlines from *Tribuna da Imprensa*, *Jornal do Brasil*, and *Folha de S. Paulo* documenting the rapid deterioration of President José Sarney's popularity following the November 1986 elections. These stories highlight the abrupt resurgence of inflation, increased political pressure on the executive, and internal divisions within the governing coalition. This environment is consistent with the main-text discussion that the government entered the NCA with limited political capital and relied heavily on individualized legislative bargaining.



Figure B2: Newspaper headlines illustrating the post-election collapse of the *Cruzado* plan and the resulting decline in presidential popularity.

C Contentious Votes in the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly

This appendix documents the procedure used to assemble and classify the voting records of the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly (NCA), and provides background on the key legislative issues used in the empirical analysis. We relied on the official historical archive maintained by the Brazilian Chamber of Deputies, including the “25 anos da Constituição” digital collection.¹⁰ All vote tallies, roll-call sheets, and government statements in this appendix come directly from these primary sources.

Data construction and coding procedure

The NCA voting records are preserved in heterogeneous formats, including scanned PDF documents, typed lists, and transcribed minutes. To convert these materials into a structured dataset, we implemented a multi-step workflow:

1. **Digitization via OCR.** Original roll-call sheets were processed using Optical Character Recognition (OCR) tools. Manual inspection ensured accuracy in names, vote options, and abstention codes.
2. **Name standardization.** Deputy names were standardized using a Stata/R cleaning routine that harmonized spelling variations, abbreviations, married names, and typographical inconsistencies. These standardized names were merged with the 1986 electoral registry to uniquely identify each deputy.
3. **Vote classification.** Each voting session was examined to extract the possible voting options (e.g., *Sim*, *Não*, *Abstenção*, *Obstrução*). When different abstention types appeared, they were harmonized to a single “abstain” category.
4. **Government position coding.** Using official transcripts of the 1987–88 National Constituent Assembly (ANC), we identified the Executive’s stated position for each roll-call vote. Government floor leaders—particularly Deputy Mário Covas—publicly announced whether the Executive supported or opposed each amendment or motion. Based on these declarations in the plenary records, each roll-call was coded as “government *FOR*” or “government *AGAINST*.”

¹⁰Available at: <https://www2.camara.leg.br/atividade-legislativa/plenario/discursos/escrevendohistoria/25-anos-da-constituicao-de-1988/momentos-marcantes-da-constituente>.

5. **Deputy-level loyalty index.** For each deputy i , topic t , and roll-call v , we coded:

$$Loyalty_{ivt} = \begin{cases} 1, & \text{if pro-government vote,} \\ 0, & \text{if anti-government vote.} \end{cases}$$

Abstentions were coded according to the “expected action” implied by the government’s stated preference (e.g., an abstention counted as opposition when the government needed an affirmative vote). For each deputy–topic pair, we then averaged $Loyalty_{ivt}$ across all votes v belonging to topic t :

$$Loyalty_{it} = \frac{1}{N_t} \sum_{v=1}^{N_t} Loyalty_{ivt},$$

yielding a measure of alignment between 0 and 1 for each deputy and each substantive issue debated in the Assembly.

The resulting dataset contains a harmonized panel of deputies $\times$ key topics, enabling the empirical analysis reported in Section 5.

O Sr. Roberto Freire — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.	A Emenda foi rejeitada.	
O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte Roberto Freire.	VOTARAM OS SRS. CONSTITUINTES:	
O SR. ROBERTO FREIRE (PCB — PE. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, defendendo os direitos dos trabalhadores por uma jornada de quarenta horas, o Partido Comunista Brasileiro votará “sim”.	Presidente Ulysses Guimarães — Abstenção	
O Sr. José Maria Eymael — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.	Abigail Feitosa — Sim	Darcy Deitos — Não
O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte José Maria Eymael.	Acival Gomes — Sim	Darcy Pozza — Não
O SR. JOSÉ MARIA EYMAEL (PDC — SP. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, o PDC foi co-autor da proposta de 44 horas semanais, visando a um equilíbrio. Dentro do espírito do acordo do primeiro turno, encaminho contrariamente a votação.	Adauto Pereira — Não	Del Bosco Amaral — Sim
O Sr. Nelson Jobim — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.	Ademir Andrade — Sim	Delfim Netto — Não
O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte Nelson Jobim.	Adhemar de Barros Filho — Sim	Délio Braz — Não
O SR. NELSON JOBIM (PMDB — RS. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, o texto básico faz parte de algo que foi construído pelo PMDB na Comissão de Sistematização e que se reproduziu no primeiro turno. Portanto, o PMDB fica com o Relator, mantém a coerência de sua posição e vota “não”.	Adolfo Oliveira — Sim	Denisar Arneiro — Não
O Sr. Artur da Távola — Sr. Presidente, peço a palavra, pela ordem.	Adroaldo Streck — Não	Dionísio Hage — Não
O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Tem a palavra, pela ordem, o nobre Constituinte Artur da Távola.	Adylson Motta — Não	Dirce Tutu Quadros — Sim
O SR. ARTUR DA TÁVOLA (PSDB — RJ. Sem revisão do orador.) — Sr. Presidente, a questão é aberta no PSDB.	Aécio de Borba — Não	Dirceu Carneiro — Não
O SR. PRESIDENTE (Ulysses Guimarães) — Passamos à votação.	Aécio Neves — Abstenção	Divaldo Suruagy — Não
	Afif Domingos — Não	Djenal Gonçalves — Não
	Afonso Sancho — Não	Domingos Leonelli — Sim
	Albano Franco — Não	Doreto Campanari — Sim
	Albérico Cordeiro — Não	Edésio Frias — Sim
	Alceni Guerra — Abstenção	Edivaldo Motta — Sim
	Aldo Arantes — Sim	Edme Tavares — Não
	Alfredo Campos — Não	Edmilson Valentim — Sim
	Aloysio Chaves — Não	Eduardo Bonfim — Sim
	Aluizio Campos — Não	Eduardo Jorge — Sim
	Alysson Paulinelli — Não	Egídio Ferreira Lima — Não
	Amaury Müller — Sim	Elias Murad — Sim
	Ângelo Magalhães — Não	Eliel Rodrigues — Não
	Anna Maria Rattes — Sim	Enoc Vieira — Não
	Annibal Barcellos — Não	Eraldo Tinoco — Não
	Antero de Barros — Sim	Eraldo Trindade — Sim
	Antônio Câmara — Não	Erico Pegoraro — Não
	Antônio Carlos Konder Reis — Não	Ervin Bonkoski — Não
	Antonio Gaspar — Sim	Etevaldo Nogueira — Não
	Antonio Mariz — Sim	Euclides Scalco — Não
	Antonio Perosa — Não	Eunice Michiles — Não
	Antonio Ueno — Não	Evaldo Gonçalves — Sim
	Arnaldo Faria de Sá — Sim	Expedito Machado — Não
	Arnaldo Martins — Não	Ézio Ferreira — Não
	Arnaldo Moraes — Não	Fábio Feldmann — Sim
	Arnaldo Prieto — Não	Farabulini Júnior — Sim
	Arnold Fioravante — Não	Fausto Fernandes — Não
	Artur da Távola — Sim	Fausto Rocha — Não
	Átila Lira — Não	Felipe Mendes — Não
	Augusto Carvalho — Sim	Fernando Bezerra Coelho — Não
	Basílio Villani — Não	Fernando Gasparian — Não
	Benedicto Monteiro — Não	Fernando Gomes — Não
	Benedita da Silva — Sim	Fernando Santana — Sim
	Benito Gama — Não	Firmino de Castro — Não
	Bernardo Cabral — Não	Flavio Palmier da Veiga — Não
	Beth Azize — Sim	Flávio Rocha — Não
		Florestan Fernandes — Sim
		Florêncio Paixão — Sim
		França Teixeira — Sim
		Francisco Amaral — Sim

Figure C1

Example of original roll-call voting sheets used to construct the NCA legislative dataset.

Notes: These documents were obtained from the official archive of the Chamber of Deputies. All sheets were digitized using OCR, manually reviewed, and linked to the 1986 electoral registry after name standardization.

Contentious topics

Below we summarize the substantive content, ideological cleavages, and government positions on the six major issues analyzed in the paper. All descriptions draw on the Chamber of Deputies' official historical records.

Agrarian Reform. Agrarian reform was among the most ideologically polarized issues of the NCA. Central to the debate was the principle that rural property must fulfill a "social function," determined by rational land use, environmental compliance, labor protections, and worker welfare. Highly contentious motions concerned whether non-compliant properties could be expropriated, how compensation would be structured (e.g., debt bonds), and whether productive properties should be shielded from redistribution. The government generally supported measures enabling expropriation and institutionalizing the social function requirement, but it faced defeats on amendments seeking to remove protections for productive properties.

Right to Strike. The right to strike generated intense debate, especially regarding civil servants and essential services. Proposals ranged from broad constitutional guarantees to more restrictive formulations limiting the scope of lawful strikes. The government consistently backed measures that upheld the general right to strike and worker participation in strike-related regulation while opposing amendments that would impose significantly narrower interpretations or constraints, particularly for public-sector workers.

Job Stability. Discussions on job stability centered on balancing worker protection with employer flexibility. Deputies debated the constitutionalization of dismissal rules, safeguards against arbitrary layoffs, and the conditions under which stability could be overridden. The government supported moderate protections but opposed amendments introducing rigid dismissal constraints. Government-supported provisions were approved, whereas more restrictive motions failed.

Working Hours. Working-hour regulation generated conflict between groups advocating stronger labor protections and those pushing for greater flexibility. Key proposals included establishing an eight-hour workday and reducing the weekly limit from 48 to 44 hours, while permitting compensatory arrangements. Conservatives opposed more rigid proposals, such as the six-hour daily limit; these failed. Government-

backed amendments allowing compensatory flexibility passed, while stricter proposals were rejected.

Property Rights. Property rights debates addressed the tension between constitutional guarantees of private property and the possibility of regulation for public interest. Proposals included unconditional property guarantees, limitations for legal non-compliance, and protections against arbitrary expropriation. The government’s position varied: it opposed unconditional guarantees but supported conditional regulatory mechanisms, though these often failed to pass due to insufficient support.

Presidential System of Government. The vote on Collective Amendment 1830—the proposal affirming presidentialism as Brazil’s system of government—exposed internal divisions within the PMDB. Leaders such as Mário Covas voted against the amendment. Because the government did not adopt a unified position, we treat this vote descriptively and do not use it in the empirical analysis of government loyalty.

Length of Presidential Term. The length of the presidential term was one of the most politically charged issues. President José Sarney and conservative allies pushed for a five-year term, citing institutional stability. Progressive factions advocated for a four-year term to force earlier elections. These groups viewed a shorter term as a chance to break with the unpopular Sarney administration and open space for political renewal. Amendments proposing shorter terms were rejected, and the five-year mandate prevailed.

Empirical specification. To quantify whether media concessions influenced legislative behavior in Section 5, we estimate:

$$Loyalty_{it} = \alpha + \beta \cdot Concession_i + \gamma_P \times \delta_S + \epsilon_{it},$$

where $Loyalty_{it}$ is deputy i ’s alignment score on topic t ; $Concession_i$ indicates whether the deputy received a concession in 1987–88; and γ_P and δ_S are party and state fixed effects. The coefficient β captures whether concession recipients were more supportive of the Executive after conditioning on partisan and regional heterogeneity.

Summary of essential ingredients. We introduce two new but empirically grounded assumptions into an otherwise standard probabilistic voting framework. First, building on the extensive literature on political campaign spending (e.g., Levitt, 1994; Gerber, 1998), political budget cycles (Rogoff and Sibert, 1988; Rogoff, 1990), and pork-barrel politics (Baron and Ferejohn, 1989; Dixit and Londregan, 1996), and in contrast to the classic assumption of exogenous valence in probabilistic voting models (Lindbeck and Weibull, 1987; Dixit and Londregan, 1996), we assume that incumbents can strategically invest in their own electoral valence. Specifically, incumbent legislators trade current legislative votes for media concessions that endogenously increase their perceived competence or popularity in future elections. Second, consistent with consolidated empirical evidence that media exposure and slant causally affect electoral behavior (e.g., DellaVigna and Kaplan, 2007; Knight and Chiang, 2011; Gentzkow, Shapiro, and Sinkinson, 2011), we assume that such media concessions translate into higher future vote shares for the incumbent independently of policy positioning.

Novelty of the mechanism. Our framework differs in fundamental ways from the main theoretical approaches to electoral resource allocation. First, in models of campaign spending, candidates directly purchase electoral support through advertising or mobilization expenditures, with spending entering the vote-share function as a separable persuasive instrument that is independent of legislative bargaining and policy implementation. Second, in pork-barrel models, targeted transfers increase voters' material welfare, and electoral gains arise because redistribution alters economic outcomes in favored districts. By contrast, in our model legislative concessions do not generate material transfers nor operate as pure advertising outlays; instead, they emerge from executive–legislative bargaining and endogenously produce a valence shift that affects voter utility independently of policy.

Agents. We present a probabilistic voting model with executive, legislative, and voters. We start by presenting the preferences of each agent and their choices in a timeline. We close the section by presenting propositions about the equilibrium and comparative statics.

Legislators. Each district $l \in [0, 1]$ is represented by an incumbent legislator, denoted by I . Each legislator will face future legislative elections against one challenger, denoted by C . Both the incumbent and the challenger are office-motivated and maximize the probability of winning the election in their district.

The incumbent chooses a policy platform $p \in [0, h]$ that is increasing in redistri-

bution. $h > 0$ denotes the upper bound of the policy domain and corresponds to the maximum level of redistribution.

Voters. There is a continuum of districts indexed by $l \in [0, 1]$. Within each district l , there is a continuum of voters indexed by $j \in [0, 1]$. Voters have single-peaked quadratic preferences over the policy p .

The ideal point of voter j in district l is denoted by $v_{j,l}$ and is distributed uniformly around the district median according to the uniform distribution

$$v_{j,l} \sim U[p_l^* - d, p_l^* + d],$$

where $d > 0$ measures the dispersion of voter preferences within the district and $p_l^* \in [0, h]$ is the bliss point of the median voter in district l .

The utility of voter j in district l from candidate $k \in \{I, C\}$, who proposes policy p_k , is given by

$$u_{j,l}(p_k) = -(p_k - v_{j,l})^2 + \theta_k,$$

where θ_k is a candidate-specific valence term.

The challenger's valence is normalized to zero, $\theta_C = 0$. The incumbent's valence depends on media exposure and is given by

$$\theta_I = \theta_0 + \gamma b_l,$$

where $b_l \geq 0$ denotes media concessions allocated in district l , and $\gamma > 0$ measures the effectiveness of media exposure in increasing electoral support.

Media concessions therefore generate a valence advantage γb_l for the incumbent, shifting voter utility independently of policy.

Voters.

Legislative.

Executive.

Timeline.

Model solution. Posit each maximization problem and then each interaction between the best response. Simultaneous game between challenger and incumbent. Sequential game between executive and legislative.

Choices of legislative politicians. The challenger adopts the policy preferred by the median voter of the district, denoted by p_l^* .

Proposition 1. Equilibrium b and p . Mention that the model trivially predict $b=0$ for challenger. Derive closed form solution both for interior and corner solution.

Proposition 2. Comparative statics.

Proposition 3. Comparative statics.